THE GUIDE IN ONE PAGE

Five moves, ranked by the research

Strong = several high-quality studies show it works. **Moderate** = good studies point that way, but fewer or less certain.

1 **Teach vocabulary on purpose**
STRONG · EVERY TEACHER

2 **Show students how good readers think**
STRONG · EVERY TEACHER

3 **Let students talk about what the reading means**
MODERATE · EVERY TEACHER

4 **Give students reasons to want to read**
MODERATE · EVERY TEACHER

5 **Get struggling readers real, extra help**
STRONG · SPECIALISTS + SCHOOLS

"Reading is every teacher's job." Moves 1–4 fit inside any lesson, in any subject.

THE FINE PRINT

- The original guide was published in **2008**. Its recommendations are still widely used, but newer research exists.
- It does not cover the reading and writing habits of each subject (how a scientist reads differently from a historian). The panel left those out because the evidence was not yet strong enough.
- The **"For English learners"** notes inside are additions for EL teachers. They are not part of the guide.

SOURCE

Kamil, M. L., Borman, G. D., Dole, J., Kral, C. C., Salinger, T., and Torgesen, J. (2008). *Improving Adolescent Literacy: Effective Classroom and Intervention Practices* (NCEE 2008-4027). Institute of Education Sciences, What Works Clearinghouse.

EL *Publishing*
MANY VOICES · ONE STORM

Plain-English version by **Richard A. Daniel, M.Ed.**, ENL/EL Specialist

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radan55.github.io/everyteacher

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A PLAIN-ENGLISH GUIDE FOR TEACHERS

Improving Adolescent *Literacy*

Five research-backed moves that help students in grades 4–12 understand what they read, in every class.

VOCABULARY · COMPREHENSION · DISCUSSION · MOTIVATION · INTERVENTION

Based on the U.S. Institute of Education Sciences practice guide, What Works Clearinghouse (2008)

EL *Publishing*

1 Teach vocabulary on purpose

STRONG EVIDENCE

Teach key words directly, then make students see, say and use them again and again. It can take up to **17 encounters** to own a new word.

- Spend a few minutes before reading on the words that carry the content.
- Choose by importance to your subject, not by how common the word is.
- Repeat the words over days; have students use them in talk and writing.
- Teach word parts, context clues and the glossary.

For English learners: point out cognates (*evaporation / evaporación*) and add a picture or gesture.

2 Show students how good readers think

STRONG EVIDENCE

Summarize, ask questions, paraphrase, make inferences and use organizers. Struggling readers need to be shown these, step by step.

- Name the strategy and why it helps; model it by thinking aloud.
- Guided practice, then pairs, then on their own.
- Use a text at the right level, and try it on many texts.
- Keep the goal on understanding the content.

For English learners: model slowly, post the steps, give frames: "The main idea is ___ because ___."

3 Let students talk about what it means

MODERATE EVIDENCE

Real discussion, not a quiz out loud. Students explain, disagree, give reasons and go back to the text. Agreement isn't the goal; deeper thinking is.

- Prepare a few real questions a thoughtful reader would wonder about.
- Follow up: "Why?" "Where does it say that?" "Who sees it differently?"
- Give small groups roles: leader, predictor, word-finder, summarizer.
- Close by summing up the main ideas.

For English learners: talk frames ("I agree with ___ because ___") and a minute to rehearse with a partner.

4 Give students reasons to want to read

MODERATE EVIDENCE

Motivation to read for school drops in middle and high school. Clear goals, some choice and real-life topics bring it back.

- Set goals around big ideas and give specific feedback on progress.
- Offer choice: which text, which task, how to show learning.
- Connect to students' lives and current events.
- Skip the prize contests; tie praise to real learning.

For English learners: texts that reflect students' cultures, and more than one way to show learning.

5 Get struggling readers real, extra help

STRONG EVIDENCE · SPECIALISTS

Good classroom teaching alone won't close a big reading gap. These students need focused help from a trained specialist.

- Screen, then diagnose exactly where reading breaks down.
- More need = smaller groups and more time.
- Classroom teachers: refer students who can't make sense of grade-level text.

For English learners: still learning English is not the same as a reading problem. Check home-language skills and time in the U.S., and talk with the EL specialist.

MONDAY-MORNING CHECKLIST

- [ ] Teach 3–5 key words before today's reading.
- [ ] Plan to use them again in talk and writing.
- [ ] Model one reading strategy out loud.
- [ ] Ask one real "why" question and let them discuss it.
- [ ] Give one choice or real-life connection.
- [ ] Refer students who can't read grade-level text.